

in return, they'll thank you by rewarding you with a high percentage of their fortune.

You'll need to send a "facilitation fee," however. And something will go wrong to hold up the transaction. So you'll have to send in more money, again and again, until you've sent thousands. You'll receive nothing in return.

Another take on this scam, called "4-1-9," "advance fee fraud," and other names, targets churches or other religious organizations. In this variation of the scheme, the e-mailer will desire to leave his fortune to that group. Perhaps he wants his fortune to further the good work they do, or, tugging on heartstrings, the writer says he's led a sinful life, has become a Christian, and wants to make up for his evil deeds. But the well-meaning beneficiary of this windfall must still send money, which is never enough, and probably supply banking information. More requests for facilitation fees will be sent until the bank account is gone, and the wealthy donor disappears.

Incredibly, intelligent people are still falling for this scam. Jesus was right to warn, "I am sending you out as sheep in the midst of wolves, so be wise as serpents and innocent as doves" (Matthew 10:16 ESV).

Examples of Ponzi or pyramid schemes abound. Basically, these plans involve the promise of a high return on an investment over a short period of time, with more and more investors or givers being recruited to support those already in the program. "Cash gifting," "gifting program," "matching gift" are some of the terms used in schemes that are especially attractive to Christians or others who believe their money is going to good causes. We need to be wise in evaluating any financial plan, especially one that may take advantage of our tendency to be trusting of anything that labels itself "Christian" or that promises incredibly great returns.

Making Hasty Decisions

Bud Hawkins set aside something he understood and knew how to do well (selling securities), and moved into an area where he was